

SAIL-BACKED GIANT

SPINOSAURUS

The North African giant *Spinosaurus* probably spent a lot of time in and around water, perhaps to avoid competing with other fierce carnivores on land. The creature's huge 5½-ft (1.7-m) long skull, powerfully built arms, and large claws tell us that this mighty predator could have easily caught and eaten a range of prey, including fish, and could even take down medium-sized dinosaurs. For many years, there was only one known *Spinosaurus* fossil, which was destroyed during World War II. Since then, its anatomy and behavior have become a topic of heated debate among paleontologists. Recent findings have helped shed more light on how this theropod with a spectacular "sail" on its back might have hunted and fed.

AT A GLANCE

- **LENGTH** 49 ft (15 m)
- **LIVED** 110–95 MYA
- **DIET** Carnivore
- **HABITAT** Swamps



STATS AND FACTS

The first fossil of this theropod was found by Richard Markgraf in the Bahariya Oasis in western Egypt in 1912. It was named *Spinosaurus*, meaning "spined reptile," by the German paleontologist Ernst Stromer in 1915.

WEIGHT



The few remains of *Spinosaurus* suggest that it may have weighed up to 7.2 tons (6.5 tonnes).

SPINE HEIGHT



The spines on *Spinosaurus*'s back were nearly 6½ ft (2 m) tall.

**LARGEST
SAIL**